

3 Building blocks

Margin, padding, borders, widths, heights etc. are all familiar terms and they do what you would expect them to do. One important aspect of CSS design is the use of divisions in providing greater flexibility and marking out regions within the page.

3.1 Divisions (Divs)

`<div>` elements, widely referred to as divs are HTML elements used to define areas within an HTML page. A division can encompass everything else within the `<body>` of the page or more typically be used for distinct areas such as headers, footers, navigation bars, and so on. Often, the HTML in your templates does not provide enough hooks to attach your styles. For example you wouldn't be able to turn paragraphs or headers into boxes directly. This is where divisions (henceforth referred to as divs) come into picture.

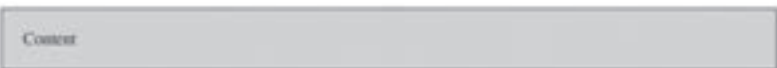
A div is created within HTML by wrapping content with the `<div>` tag. The result is a hook to which CSS can be applied.

```
<div id="container">
<p>This is our content area.</p>
</div>
```

Let's apply some simple CSS to the container ID:

```
/* Container holds all visible page elements */
#container {
padding: 20px;
border: 1px solid #000;
background: #CCC;
}
```

We have already seen how IDs and classes are used as identifiers to a standard HTML element. The same formula is used for divs by referencing the selector in the opening tag using `id="name"` or `class="name"`. In this case, we've used an ID named container to define the division:



The container div in the browser